

BEGINNER'S PHOTOGRAPHY GUIDE

50 Tips to Make You a Better Photographer

From the basic concepts to the secrets of composition
— everything you need to take photos you're proud of.

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A Word Before We Begin

I've been shooting for many years — with a Nikon D300, D700, and now the Z7. Along the way I learned a lot, mostly from mistakes. This guide is everything I wish someone had told me at the beginning.

These 50 tips don't require prior knowledge or expensive gear. They only require one thing: that you go out and shoot.

Every tip here is based on real field experience — not theory. Some will make sense immediately, others will only click after you try them. Keep this guide, and come back to it when you're stuck.

Shoot a lot. Fail. Try again. That's the whole secret.

— *Amit Erez*

Know Your Camera

Before heading out to shoot — you need to understand what you're working with. It's not painful, I promise.

1

Read the Manual — At Least Once

Most people never open it. Those who do discover features they had no idea existed. **Two hours with the manual is worth dozens of hours of trial and error.**

2

Get Off Auto — Starting Tomorrow Morning

Aperture Priority (Av or A) is the first step. You control the aperture — the camera calculates the rest. **Wide aperture (f/1.8) = bokeh. Narrow aperture (f/11) = everything sharp.**

3

Shoot RAW, Not JPEG

JPEG is a photo that has already been processed and compressed. RAW contains all the data your sensor captured — flexible for correction afterward. **Slightly off exposure? Fixable in RAW. In JPEG — not always.**

4

Three Controls That Run Everything

ISO (light sensitivity) · **Aperture** (how much light enters) · **Shutter Speed** (how long light enters). All other controls are details. First — master these three.

The Golden Triangle: Changing ISO affects noise. Changing aperture affects bokeh and depth of field. Changing shutter speed affects motion. When you change one — you need to compensate with one of the other two.

5

The Histogram Doesn't Lie — The Screen Does

Your camera's screen is a liar. In bright sun it looks too dark. At night it looks too bright. **The histogram is a real graph of exposure.** Left = dark, Right = bright. Clipped right edge = lost highlight detail.

6

Focus Lock — The Secret to Sharp Photos

Half-press the shutter to focus → reframe → full press. **This lets you place the focus point exactly where you want it**, not just in the center of the frame.

7

Three Metering Modes — Know When to Use Each

Matrix/Evaluative: Meters the whole frame — good for most situations. **Center-Weighted:** Emphasis on the center — for portraits. **Spot:** Measures a single point — for extreme lighting situations.

8

Clean Your Sensor — One Dust Spot Ruins a Thousand Photos

Dust spots show clearly on clear skies and white walls. **Test by shooting a clear blue sky at f/16 — every spot will appear clearly.** Sensor cleaning is simple and inexpensive.



f/5.6 · 1/800s · ISO 400



105mm macro · f/4 · 1/500s

Nailing Exposure

Exposure isn't just "bright or dark" — it's complete control over how much light enters your photo.

9

Getting Exposure Right in the Field Beats Fixing in Post

Post-processing is a tool — not magic. **A correctly exposed photo preserves detail in both shadows and highlights.** A blown photo has no highlight detail, no matter how far you push the slider.

10

ETTR — Expose to the Right

Expose as brightly as possible without blowing highlights. **The histogram should approach the right edge without touching it.** This reduces noise and preserves shadow detail.

11

ISO — Always Start from the Lowest Setting

High ISO = high light sensitivity = more noise. **ISO 100–400: clean. ISO 800–1600: acceptable. ISO 3200+: noisy** (camera-dependent). Always start at ISO 100 and go up only when necessary.

12

The Shutter Speed Rule of Thumb — Prevent Camera Shake

Shutter speed no slower than **1/focal length**. With a 50mm lens → minimum 1/60s. With 200mm → minimum 1/200s. **With image stabilization — you can go 2–4 stops below that.**

Quick tip: Auto-ISO with a manual ceiling (e.g., ISO 3200) + minimum shutter speed (e.g., 1/125s) = the camera manages ISO automatically while maintaining a shake-free shutter speed. A game-changing setting.

13

Auto-ISO with a Manual Ceiling — The Setting That Changes Everything

Set Auto-ISO with a minimum shutter speed in your camera settings. **The camera raises ISO only when needed to maintain shutter speed.** Perfect for sports and events.

14

ND Filter — Long Exposures in Daylight

ND darkens light without changing color. **ND10 = 10 stops of light = seconds-long exposure in bright daylight.** Flowing water becomes silky white. The sea becomes a mirror. Clouds become soft fabric.

15

Exposure Compensation (+/-) — The Most Useful Tool

The +/- button adds or subtracts exposure without changing mode. **Snow? +1 stop. Dark subject against bright background? -1 stop.** Most cameras give you quick access to this button — use it constantly.

16

Backlit Subjects — Meter on the Face, Not the Background

When the background is brighter than the subject, the camera exposes for the background — and your subject comes out dark. **Fix: Spot Metering on the face, or Exposure Compensation +1 to +2.** Alternative: fill flash.

Composition

What separates an interesting photo from a snapshot — it's not the gear, it's the choice of what enters the frame.

17

Rule of Thirds — Place Your Subject at the Intersections

Imagine two vertical and two horizontal lines dividing the frame into nine equal parts. **Place your main subject at one of the four intersection points — not the center.** Most cameras support displaying this grid in live view.

18

Leading Lines — Invite the Eye to Travel Through the Frame

Roads, fences, rivers, train tracks — **any line that starts at the edge of the frame and leads to the subject.** This creates depth and draws the viewer in. Look for them — they're everywhere.

19

Framing — Place Your Subject Inside a Natural Frame

Trees, arches, doorways, windows — **any element that surrounds the subject creates a natural frame that concentrates attention.** It also adds a layer of depth to a two-dimensional image.

20

Simplicity — Remove Everything That Doesn't Contribute

Ask yourself: **"Does every element in this frame strengthen the story, or distract from it?"** A step forward, a different angle, a wider aperture — sometimes all you need is to remove the visual noise.



White owl on white snow = clean background that emphasizes the subject. Simplicity in composition.

21

Change Your Height — Don't Always Shoot at Eye Level

From below: the subject looks large and powerful. From above: gives a sense of control and perspective. **Simply lying on the ground or standing on a bench changes everything.**

22

Breathing Room — Give Your Subject Space

If the subject is looking left — give it space on the left. A bird in flight needs room in the direction it's flying. **A frame where the subject feels "squeezed" is uncomfortable for the viewer.**

23

Horizontal vs Vertical — Try Both

Before moving on — shoot both orientations. **Landscapes are almost always horizontal. Portraits mostly vertical. Architecture — it depends.** But sometimes the unexpected orientation works better.

24

Negative Space — The Empty Area Is Part of the Photo

A small figure in a vast sky creates a sense of solitude and beauty. **Sometimes what isn't in the photo tells the story.** Don't be afraid of empty, clean backgrounds.

Understanding Light

Photography is painting with light — whoever controls the light, controls the image.

25

Golden Hour — Worth More Than Any Gear

One hour after sunrise and one hour before sunset: the light is warm, soft, and low.

Skin in golden hour looks perfect. Landscape in golden hour looks magical. No filter replicates it. Wake up early.

26

Blue Hour — The Photographers' Secret

Twenty minutes before sunrise and after sunset: the sky turns into a deep, gentle, even blue. **City lights on, deep blue sky — a combination you can't miss.** This is when to shoot cities at night.

27

Overcast Day Is a Gift for Portraits

Clouds diffuse sunlight into soft, ambient illumination — **a giant free softbox.** No harsh shadows, no squinting eyes, no extreme contrast. Perfect for portraits and macro.

28

Light Direction — Three Completely Different Effects

Front light: Flat, no shadows, bright faces. **Side light:** Dramatic, emphasizes textures. **Back light (rim light):** Mystical, separates subject from background. **Try rotating the subject relative to the light — don't move yourself.**

Quick tip: A piece of white cardboard reflects light onto faces in shadow. A professional reflector does the same thing — just more convenient to carry. Before buying one — try cardboard.

29

Reflector — The Cheapest Gear with the Most Impact

A 5-in-1 reflector costs almost nothing and transforms every portrait. **Silver = sharp and contrasty. Gold = warm and soft. White = subtle and natural.** I always have one in my bag.

30

Flash in Daylight — Not Just for Night

When strong sun is behind the subject, fill flash adds light to faces. **Low power (-1 to -2 stops) = completely natural.** Nobody will know you used flash.

31

Look for Special Light — It's Waiting for You

A shaft of light through a window, rays between trees, the opening of a tunnel, neon lights in rain. **The most dramatic light is usually free — you just need to notice it and wait.**

Lenses & Gear

Gear is a tool — not the story. But a good tool helps.

32

A Good Lens Beats an Expensive Camera Body

An f/1.4 lens on an old body will beat an expensive body with a kit lens every time.

Limited budget? Buy a modest body + a good prime lens. Optical glass doesn't age like a camera body.

33

50mm f/1.8 — The First Lens You Should Buy

Inexpensive (\$100–200), light, sharp, with beautiful bokeh and a wide aperture for low light. **The "Nifty Fifty" — a nickname that fits perfectly.** The angle is close to the human eye = photos that feel natural.

34

Tripod — Not Optional, Mandatory

Long exposures, sunrise landscapes, macro, night — impossible without a tripod.

Carbon fiber: light and stable. Worth investing in — a good tripod lasts twenty years.

35

UV Filter — Cheap Insurance for Expensive Glass

Protects the front element from scratches, fingerprints and moisture. **A \$2,000 lens + a \$30 UV filter = armor.** Always on every lens. Never removed.

36

Less Gear = More Creativity

Don't take everything everywhere. **Constraints force creative solutions.** One day with a single lens teaches more about photography than a week with the whole bag.

37

Teleconverter — Extend Your Reach Without Buying a New Lens

A 1.4× TC on a 300mm lens = 420mm. A 2× TC = 600mm. **Much less expensive than a new telephoto lens.** Cost: you lose light (1.4× = one stop, 2× = two stops).

38

Lens Cleaning — Only This Way, No Other

Gentle breath to lift dust + clean microfiber cloth, gentle circular wipe. Tissue, your shirt, paper towels — forbidden. They scratch the coating. Dedicated lens cleaning solution — allowed.

Editing

Good editing brings a photo to its potential — it doesn't rescue it.

39

Editing Enhances — It Doesn't Save

A photo with composition problems, bad focus or extreme exposure won't become a good photo in editing. **Rule one: shoot well in the field. Editing is the finishing touch.**

40

Always Start with Exposure and White Balance

Before anything else — **fix the basic exposure and White Balance.** Every subsequent adjustment to color, contrast and detail will be far more accurate once the foundation is right.

41

Less Saturation — Almost Always

Beginners overdo color. **Saturation of 10–20 is enough for most photos.** To check: convert to black and white, then restore color — if the color jumps out at you, you've overdone it.

42

Clarity — Use It Carefully

Clarity adds sharpness to mid-range textures. **Excellent for landscapes, rocks, wood. Destructive for portraits** — turns skin into a lunar landscape. If you shot faces — Clarity at 0 or slightly negative.

43

Save a Preset — Save Hours

When you find a style you love — save it as a Preset in Lightroom. **Next time: select, click, done.** Consistent editing also builds a recognizable "signature style".

44

Compare Before and After — Sometimes the Original Is Better

After finishing your edit — press \ in Lightroom to see before and after. **Sometimes thirty minutes of editing ruined a photo that was perfect.** There's always undo.

Mindset & Practice

The best gear in the world doesn't shoot for you. Habits do.

45

Shoot Every Day — Even with Your Phone

Your eye trains itself through shooting. **Someone who shoots daily for a year takes far better photos than someone who goes out with expensive gear once a month.** The phone in your pocket is the best camera you have — because it's always with you.

46

Learn from Photos You Love — Analyze Them

When you see an impressive photo — stop and ask: **Where's the light coming from? What's the composition? What lens? What made me stop?** Analyzing five photos a day is worth a professional lesson.

47

Accept Critique — It Doesn't Hurt as Much as You Think

Show your work to people you respect and sincerely ask what isn't working. **One honest critique is worth a hundred "great shots!" from people who don't want to hurt your feelings.**

48

Fewer Shots = More Thinking

Digital cameras tempt us to shoot hundreds of frames hoping one will be good. **Try the opposite: stand before your subject, think about the frame, then shoot — once.** The improvement is immediate.

49

Fall in Love with Your Subject

The best photographers shoot what they love — birds, landscapes, children, food. **Love for the subject creates patience, persistence and attention to detail that can't be faked.**

50

Most Important — Go Out and Shoot

All the knowledge in the world is worthless without going out to the field. **The best camera is the one you have in your hand. The best gear is the gear you actually take with you.** Now — go shoot.



300mm · f/6.3 · 1/2000s



300mm · f/5.6 · 1/3200s



Amit Erez — Photographer

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